

Q Being the world's first provider of the Enterprise Linux distribution, how has SUSE evolved over time vis-a-vis developments in the open source ecosystem?

A: We, at SUSE, and our team have always been passionate about bringing true open source innovations to our customers, right from when we started 27 years ago, with the first ever Enterprise Linux distribution, through to when we marked our renewed independence on March 15 this year. Today, we continue that passion with an expanded portfolio of leading-edge open source solutions for software-defined infrastructure and application delivery, which allow enterprises to run their workloads anywhere – on premise, in the cloud, or both.

At SUSECON this year, we announced that we are delivering new hybrid and multi-cloud capabilities and application delivery innovations to help customers transform their digital infrastructures in their own way as quickly as they need to.

Q Please share some of the recent contributions made by SUSE to open source.

A: SUSE works 'upstream first' in all of its projects. This means that when we are doing development work for our own distributions, we contribute directly into the open source community before packaging for QA and delivery to our customers. Linux itself is made up of thousands of tiny programs, any one of which we might contribute to over the course of a release. On top of that, we are regularly engaged with more than 100 significant open source projects, and work within the communities to deliver and support enterprise-grade Linux, software-defined infrastructure and application delivery solutions. Along with contributing code and documentation to many projects, we are a founding member of more than 10 open source organisations and have board representation on the foundations governing projects such as OpenStack, Linux, Cloud Foundry, Cloud-Native

Computing (CNCF), OPNFV (a Linux Foundation Networking umbrella project), Open Mainframe and OpenHPC.

We believe that continuously sharing development work with community projects first, rather than keeping hold of new ideas and only releasing them to communities once a product is available, creates a stronger ecosystem and provides a more dependable foundation for our customers. The recent launch of SUSE Cloud Application Platform 1.4 is a great example of how SUSE is bringing the Kubernetes and Cloud Foundry communities together. SUSE Cloud Application Platform 1.4 is the first distribution to introduce a Cloud Foundry Application Runtime in an entirely Kubernetes-native architecture. It brings together the best of both worlds for lightweight deployment and rapid development of applications, as well as increases options for IT operation teams to deploy into multi-cloud environments.

“One of the great advantages of open source is that ideas don't get lost, as they can be when a proprietary company shuts down a product or gets acquired”

Q How do you see the role of the Indian government in promoting open source software in the country?

A: We are glad to see the Indian government adopting freedom of choice by leveraging the scalability and robustness of open source software, and encouraging the public sector to opt for open source through more concrete and comprehensive policies. The initiatives to introduce the use of open standards and open source technologies in the public sector will help India to strengthen its position in IT and bridge

the digital divide with significant cost savings. This will facilitate the creation of what the Indian government wants — “a digitally empowered society and knowledge economy.”

Q How can open source play a role in empowering India digitally and ensuring the success of Digital India? Is SUSE playing or planning to play any role in such government initiatives?

A: The Indian government has been backing open source software development and the announcement of the open source policy has given massive impetus to this segment. The policy mandates that state-run departments promote and adopt open source for their software applications and services. This has given a significant push to innovation in the government departments, leading to better services for citizens. We are sure that open source can help greatly in bridging the digital divide in the country.

We see a significant opportunity for open source with the introduction of Make in India, where SUSE is enabling cloud services and value-added service providers with cutting-edge, enterprise-class open source technologies. With respect to smart cities, too, we are currently working with a host of projects around the country.

Q What kind of association do you have with vendors and partners in the technology space?

A: India is a very important market for SUSE. In this market, we are 100 per cent channel driven, which means that partnership is the key to our success. We work through three levels of partners — large global systems integrators (who are based in India), local and global technology partners (including independent hardware vendors and cloud service providers), and state or city-specific partners. Our channel programme is based on 'Technology' certification, in which partners are assessed on their understanding of SUSE solutions and their capacity to support end customers.